

"Many people have said many things. I can only say I did not consciously go after dance. It found me."

POETRY IN MOTION

A rebel who horrified her orthodox community, she reinvented Bharatanatyam, eliminating the erotic and introducing the devout. A feminist far ahead of her time, she created a school which evolved into a form of dance.

Rukmini Devi Arundale

Dancer 1904-1986

■ By Leela Samson

Not many women are offered presidency of a country and even fewer, refuse.

Rukmini Devi Arundale was one such woman who declined the high office when Morarji Desai offered it on a platter in 1977. She understood that Kalakshetra, the academy of arts that she had set up, simply needed her more than the Rashtrapati Bhavan. She had a chequered and fascinating life as a visionary, artist, educationist, theosophist, dancer and a choreographer par excellence; an institution builder, a staunch friend of animals worldwide, a stauncher advocate of vegetarianism, promoter of traditional Indian arts and crafts, a wise thinker, orator and above all a great humanitarian.

At 16, the girl from an orthodox Tamil Brahmin family, born in 1904 and brought up in Madurai, stirred the community by her marriage to British theosophist George S. Arundale who was 20 years older than her. She was influenced by the Theosophical Movement, the Swadeshi Movement and by her mentor Annie Besant. She worked for the Theosophical Society, at first assisting Besant in her office, learning the ropes and later forming a youth wing of the movement that propagated the ban of slaughter of



KALAKSHETRA, CHENNAI